

STARTUP GRAVEYARD REPORT

2024

6th January, 2025

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Foreword

In recent years, the African tech startup ecosystem has been truly remarkable. Entrepreneurs are thriving throughout the continent, addressing major global challenges and creating solutions reshaping Africa and drawing international interest.

This report by Startup Graveyard Africa explores the dynamic world of African tech startups in 2024. It offers a comprehensive overview of the current startup ecosystem and provides valuable insights into the key trends, challenges, and opportunities that characterise this exciting landscape.

The report effectively details Africa's startup ecosystem, highlighting its key participants and the current situation. It also examines the harsh truth of startup failures, presenting case studies of businesses that closed in 2023 and 2024. By investigating the reasons behind these shutdowns, the report seeks to provide aspiring entrepreneurs with insights to avoid common challenges and enhance their likelihood of success.

Fortunately, the story doesn't stop here. The report highlights the successes of Africa's flourishing startups, especially those that reached unicorn status in 2024. These achievements inspire aspiring entrepreneurs and demonstrate the vast potential of the African tech sector.

Furthermore, the report acknowledges the invaluable contribution of startupgraveyard.africa to the African startup ecosystem. By documenting the journeys of failed ventures, this platform provides valuable lessons for future generations of entrepreneurs.

This report is a must-read for anyone interested in understanding the current state of Africa's tech startup scene. It offers a balanced perspective, highlighting both the challenges and the immense potential that lies ahead. As Africa continues positioning itself as a global innovation hub, this report provides the insights needed to propel the continent's tech ecosystem to even greater heights.

I invite you to explore the upcoming pages and deepen your understanding of the thrilling realm of African tech startups.

Kelvin Gobo, Founder of Startup Graveyard Africa

Introduction

The first startup, Interswitch, was launched in Africa in 2002. The company has made a name for itself by providing financial inclusion and easy digital payments. Its popular payment processing solutions include Verve and Quickteller. Mocality, a Kenyan startup, shut down in 2013. It was an online directory service that ceased operations due to fierce competition and issues with sustainability.

While Mocality is said to have been one of Africa's earliest startup shutdowns, no comprehensive directory contains data that provides factual information about this occurrence. Admittedly, the ecosystem is evolving rapidly due to economic factors, market volatility, and unfavourable regulatory policies. However, this does not excuse the need for extensive documentation, as its effects are far-reaching.

Startup Graveyard Africa was born out of the need to solve this problem. By documenting startup shutdowns and the reasons for their failures, we hope to de-stigmatize failure and provide valuable insights for other entrepreneurs, business investors, and startup enthusiasts.

The 2024 Startup Graveyard Report is the first of its kind. It promises more to come, providing extensive data about Africa's startup ecosystem and case studies about shutdowns and their causes. We hope this report will be a valuable resource for entrepreneurs and investors.

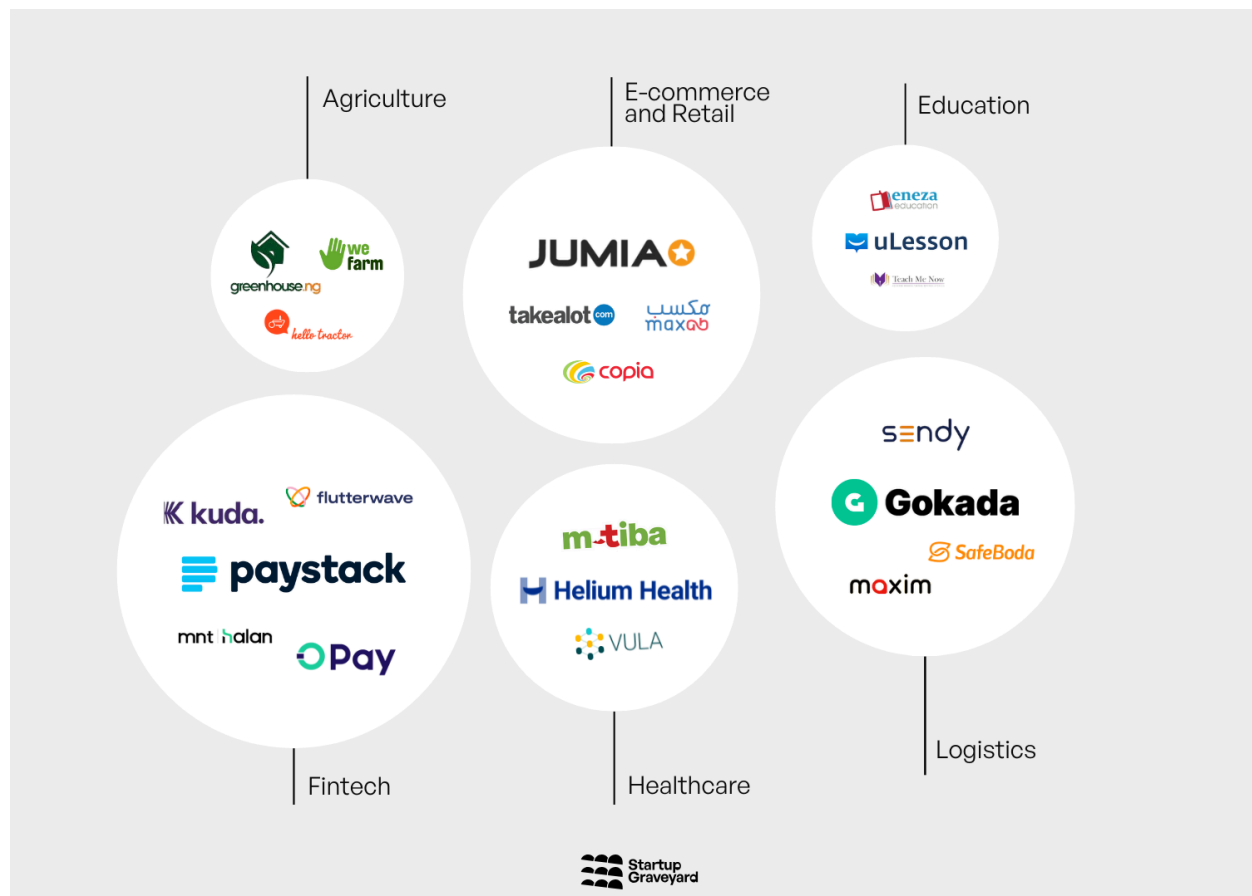
An Overview of Africa's Startup Ecosystem

Like the rest of the world, Africa has a tech-savvy population comprised mostly of young people. Over the last decade, the continent has witnessed a rise in the launch of startups across several sectors. Entrepreneurship has taken hold of the commerce sector, driven by rising unemployment rates.

Starting new businesses is the norm and occurs mainly as informal businesses. Startups that receive operational licenses and are registered with the appropriate agencies are poised to receive more funding from investors than their unregistered partners.

What are the key startup sectors?

Startups in Africa are focused on providing accessible and affordable solutions to existing and recurrent problems in specific sectors. These key sectors include finance, e-commerce and retail, healthcare, agriculture, education, and logistics.



What is the most popular startup sector?

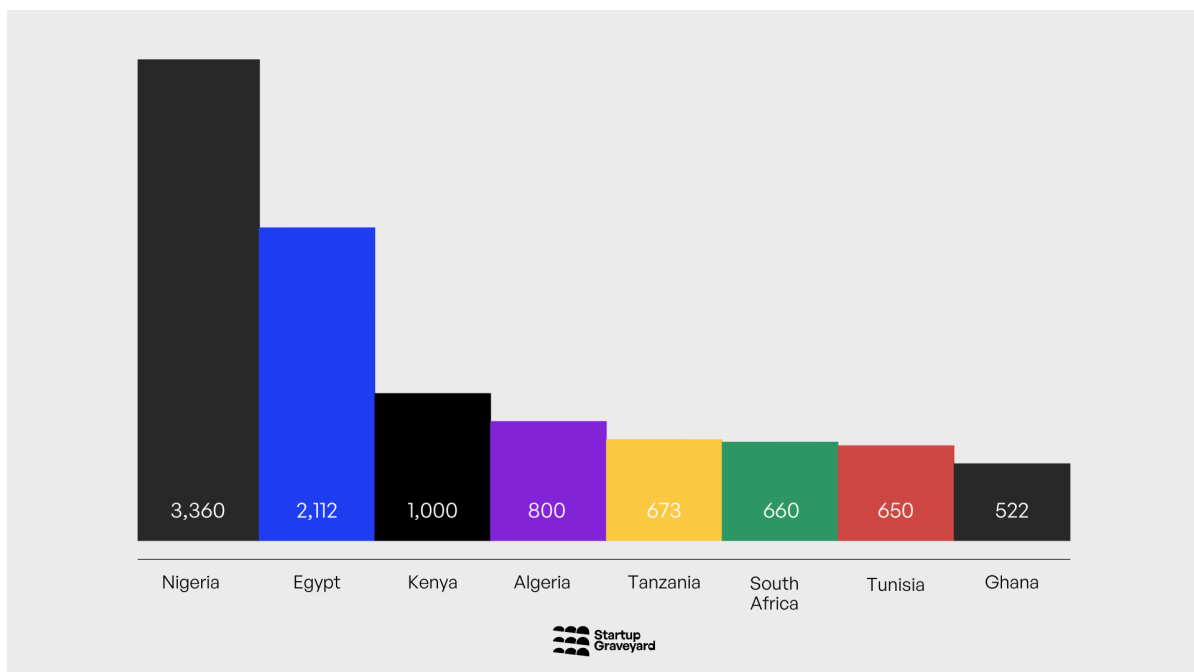
The fintech sector, short for financial technology, has gained the most traction in African business investments. Companies in this sector aim to provide easy digital payments and financial inclusion for their respective countries' largely unbanked and underbanked populations.

Fintech startups have grown exponentially due to the high number of mobile phone users on the continent, with 495 million in sub-Saharan Africa alone. Coupled with viable business models and an influx of funding from venture capital firms, this sector has achieved remarkable progress [2].

What countries have the most startups?

Nigeria, Egypt, and Kenya have been listed as countries with the highest startup activity [1]. Nigeria tops the list with 3,360 startups, followed closely by Egypt with 2,112 startups and Kenya with 1,000 startups. These countries have equally thriving state capitals, which have attracted and retained investment opportunities.

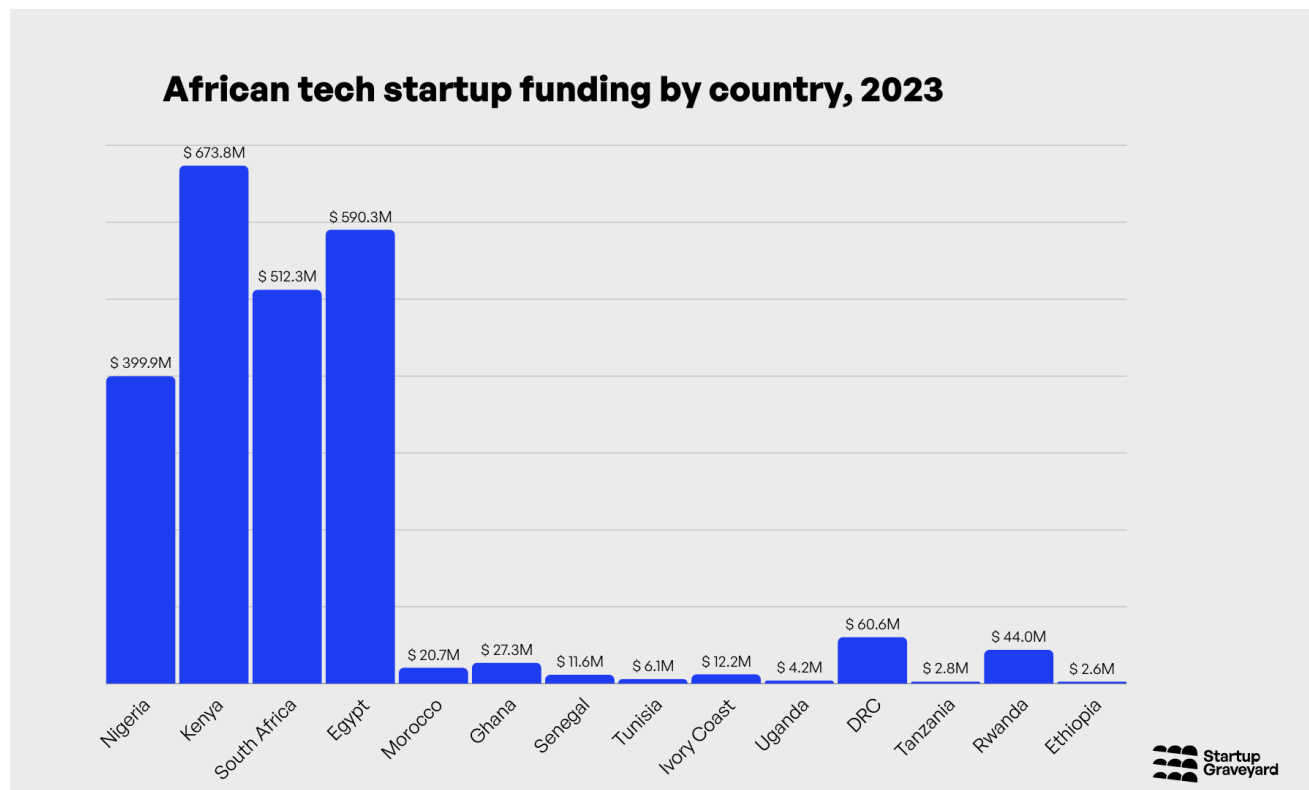
Other countries with startup activity include Ghana, South Africa, Algeria, Tunisia, and Tanzania.



Which country has the highest startup activity?

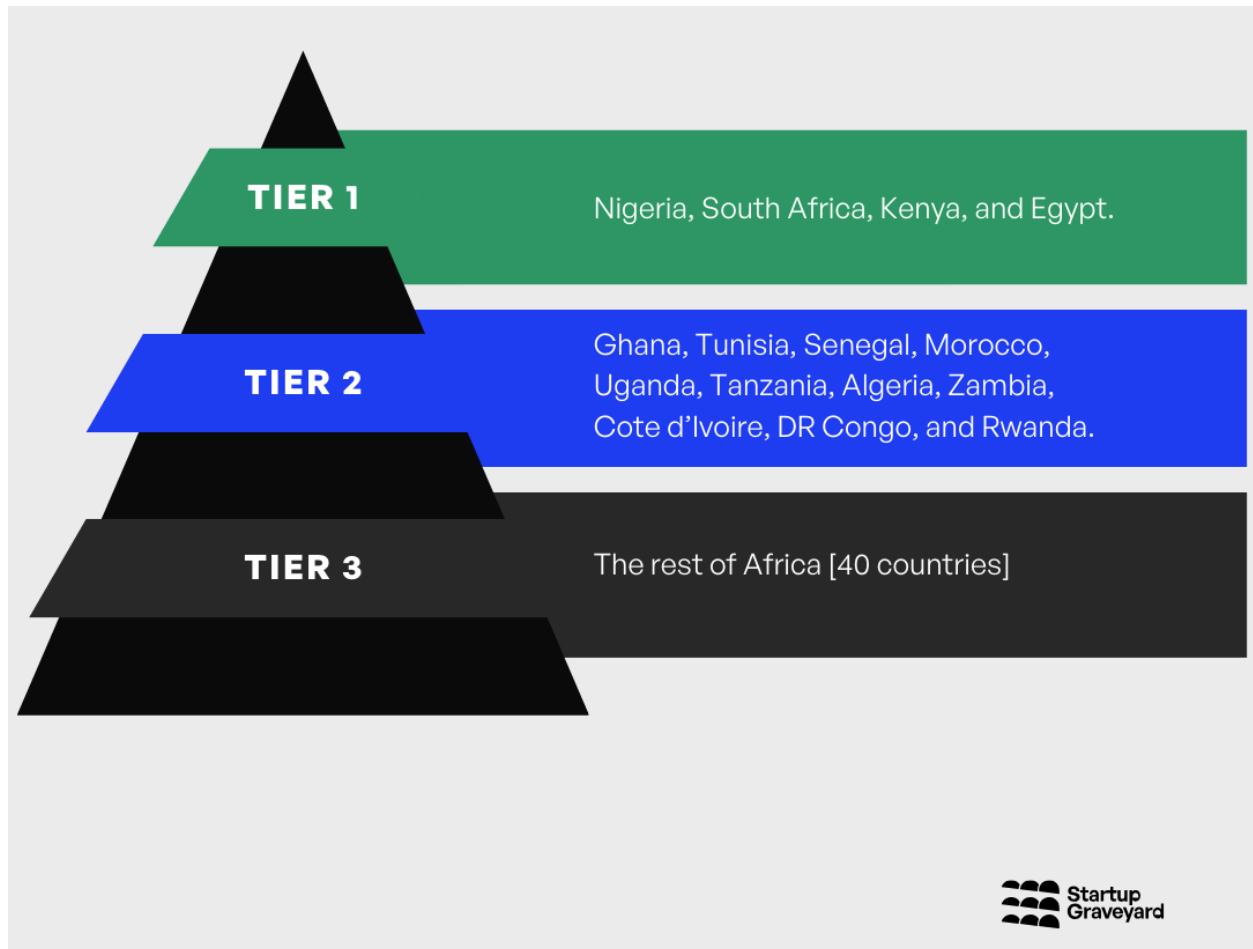
After extensive research spanning nearly a decade (2015 - 2022), Disrupt Africa named Nigeria the most popular investment destination in Nigeria. The popular physical locations for startups are Lagos, Abuja, and Ibadan. Africa's first startup, Interswitch, is headquartered in Lagos. Startup activity took off in 2011 and peaked in 2019, with fintech leading in business and funding, followed closely by e-commerce.

In Disrupt Africa's report on Nigeria's startup ecosystem, 383 tech startups raised \$2.07 billion in funding, higher than in other African countries. The fintech sector (36%) took a large chunk of this figure, with Flutterwave receiving \$250 million in series D funding. Other sectors closely following the fintech space are e-commerce (12.1%) and ed-tech (9.4%) [3].



Growth Trends in Africa's Startup Ecosystem

Mozilla's Africa Startup Ecosystem report divided Africa's startup ecosystem into tiers based on business activity, funding, and acceleration. Nigeria led in tier 1, alongside South Africa, Kenya, and Egypt. Tier 2 featured Ghana, Tunisia, Senegal, Morocco, Uganda, Tanzania, Algeria, Zambia, Cote d'Ivoire, DR Congo, and Rwanda. Tier 3 represented the rest of Africa, summing up 40 countries.



Industry Pioneers

Between 2000 and 2010, two notable startups that continuously impacted the African startup ecosystem were InterSwitch and M-Pesa.

In 2002, Mitchell Elegbe founded Interswitch, a Nigerian-based transaction processing company. Over the years, the company has clinched several partnerships and launched a \$10 million Interswitch ePayment Growth Fund in 2015 to support African startups in the fintech space.

By 2019, Interswitch was valued at \$1 billion, making it Africa's first unicorn, after receiving massive funding of \$200 million from Visa. In 2022, they raised \$110 million in a private equity round led by Tana Africa Capital. In 2023, the company celebrated its 20th anniversary, and the Central Bank of Nigeria issued the payment platform a Payments Service Holding Company (PSHC) license.

By September 2024, Interswitch had been named Fintech of the Year at the African Fintech Summit Awards. The following month, it partnered with the Nigeria Inter-Bank Settlement System (NIBBS) to enhance payment transactions [4].

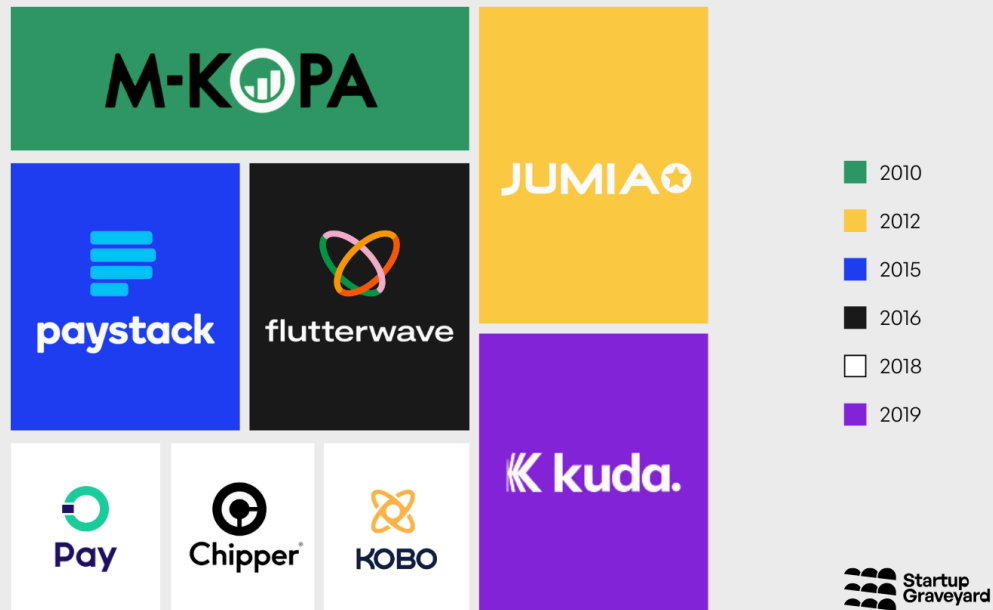
Kenya's M-Pesa was a pilot project by Safaricom and Vodafone in 2005. By 2007, it was made public as Kenya's first mobile money service provider. Its services included micro-loans, airtime purchases, and bill payments by 2010 [5]. Between 2011 and 2013, M-Pesa expanded its services to Tanzania, South Africa, and India. By 2014, they partnered with Western Union to enable international money transfers, and by 2016, M-Pesa Global was introduced to enable global remittances.

Between 2018 and 2024, M-Pesa expanded its reach to other African countries, rebranded to M-Pesa Africa, and celebrated its 15th anniversary in business. They have also served up to 66 million users and have \$314 billion in annual transactions [6].

Continued Growth and Expansion

Following the visible success of Interswitch and M-Pesa, other startups began to take root in several African countries. Paystack and Flutterwave, headquartered in Lagos, Nigeria, were founded in 2015 and 2016, aiming to simplify digital payments.

Notable African startups and when they were founded



Challenges Present in Africa's Startup Scene

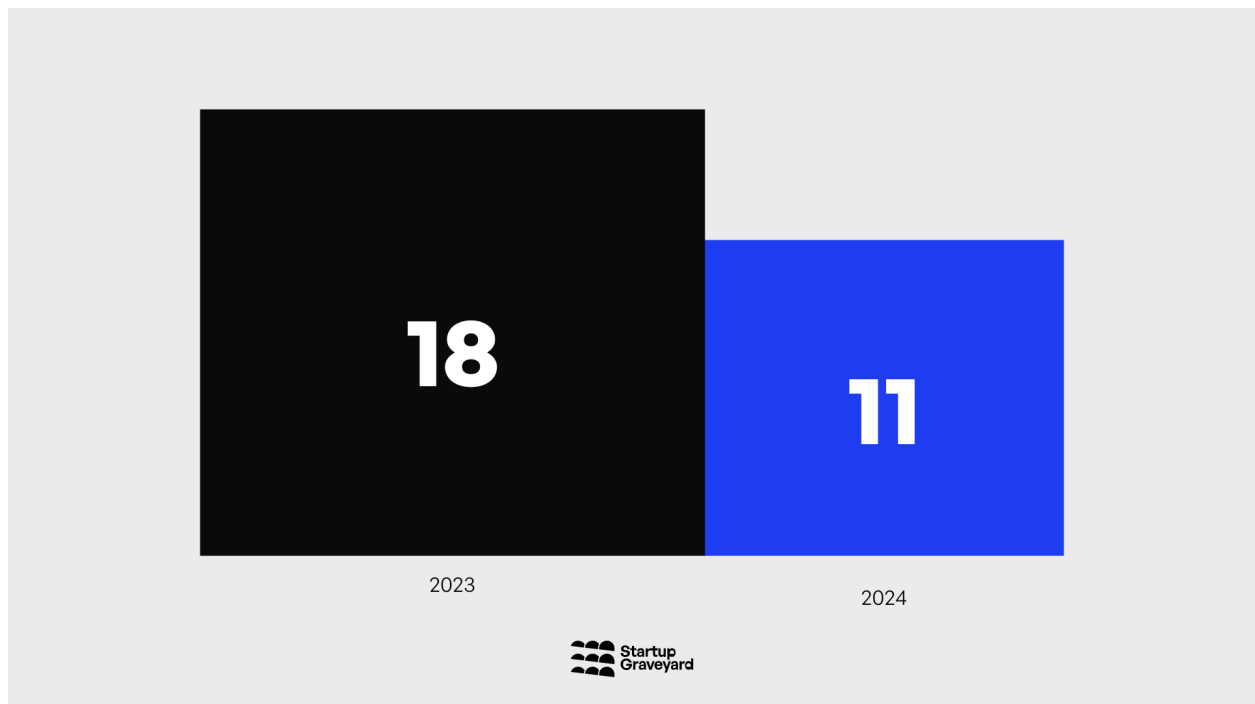
While there has been significant growth in the startup ecosystem, existing and new-found problems have affected startups and their functionality. The common problems startups have faced and continue to experience include a challenging business environment that leads to unsustainable business practices.

In addition to unhealthy regulatory practices, high tax rates when companies go fully public, inadequate government support, a lack of efficient digital infrastructure, and a scarcity of competent talent have also led to startup shutdowns [7].

Case Studies of Notable Failures

We conducted case studies on new businesses that shut down during their first five years of operation. Here's what we found.

How many startups shut down between 2023 and 2024?



From the data we've collected at the time of publishing, 18 startups shut down in 2023. They are:

- 54Gene (Nigeria)
- Lazerpay (Nigeria)
- Vibra (Nigeria)
- Pivo (Nigeria)
- Zazuu (Nigeria)
- Hytch (Nigeria)
- Kippapay (Nigeria)

- Bundle Africa (Nigeria)
- Pillow (Nigeria/Ghana)
- Okadabooks (Nigeria)
- Jumia Food (multiple countries)
- Zumi (Kenya)
- Sendy (Kenya)
- PrivPay (Kenya)
- Dash (Ghana)
- Redbird (Ghana)
- WhereIsMyTransport (South Africa)
- Capiter (Egypt)

In 2024, 11 startups shut down, hibernated or entered administration.

- ThePeer (Nigeria)
- HerRyde (Nigeria)
- Chopnownow (Nigeria)
- Cova (Nigeria)
- BuyCoinsPro(Nigeria)
- Quizac (Nigeria)
- Gro Intelligence (Kenya)
- Copia Global (Kenya)
- RejaReja (Kenya)
- iProcure (Kenya)
- LetsChat (multiple countries)

Which country had the highest startup shutdowns in 2023 and 2024?

Nigerian-based startups had the highest shutdown rates, with 18 startups reported and reported to have the highest decline in funding after retaining the top position as the most-funded African country in 2021 and 2022.

This development pushed Nigeria behind Kenya, Egypt, and South Africa. In 2022, Nigerian startups raised \$976 million in funding, which contrasts sharply with the figure raised in 2023 - \$399 million [8].

In 2024, 11 startups shut down, hibernated or entered administration. Six startups operating in Nigeria and Kenya followed closely, with four reportedly shutting down.

Some Notable Startups that Shut Down Between 2023 and 2024

Why did 54Gene shut down?

54Gene was a health-tech company focused on African genomics research. Founded by Abasi Ene-Obong, Damilola Oni, Gatumi Aliyu, and Francis Osifo in 2019, it shut down primarily due to financial mismanagement, according to reports.

54Gene raised \$45 million from investors, including the Bill Gates-Melinda Foundation and Y Combinator. While this helped them establish adequate infrastructure, they faced competition from long-standing industry players like Pfizer and GlaxoSmithKline (GSK) [\[9\]](#).

Why did LazerPay shut down?

LazerPay was a blockchain-based payment processing platform that businesses use to accept cryptocurrency payments. In 2021, Njoku Emmanuel co-founded the company with Abdulfatai Suleiman and Prosper Ubi.

LazerPay raised up to \$1.1 million in funding and reportedly helped up to 3,000 businesses receive payments in cryptocurrency. However, the company suffered a massive loss when its lead investor pulled out and ran out of funding. The core team reportedly used their savings to keep the company afloat, but this approach was unsustainable, as they eventually announced their shutdown on Twitter in April 2023 [\[10\]](#).

Why did Dash shut down?

Dash, a Ghanaian fintech startup, was founded in 2019 by Prince Boakye Boampong. The company provided an easy way to send large sums of money through mobile wallets. In 2021, Dash raised up to \$32 million in funding and expanded its operations to two African countries: Nigeria and Kenya.

Within its years of operation, Dash secured up to \$85 million in funding from five major investors. It was valued at \$200 million and processed \$1 billion in transactions from 5 million users on its digital platform.

In 2022, the Bank of Ghana stopped Dash's operations, claiming it didn't have the proper papers to run the business there. Rumours also sprang up about the company's inefficiency with finance, which led to reduced patronage. The CEO was replaced due to accusations of mishandling company funds for personal use, and internal audits revealed more discrepancies.

After this development, no further official news was shared about the company [\[11\]](#).

Why did Sendy shut down?

Kenya's Sendy was a logistics company founded by Meshack Alloys, Evanson Biwott, and Don Okoth in 2021. It provided seamless logistics services and started operations with registered motorcycles and autorickshaw riders who delivered goods on demand. In 2016, Sendy launched Sendy Ride, an online taxi order app, and in the following years, it launched Sendy Transport and Sendy Supply, establishing itself in Kenya's transport and logistics sector.

In 2022, Sendy experienced a downturn in business, a ripple effect of the funding drought, and expensive lending rates by developed countries. They transitioned from offering B2C services to B2B solely and slashed up to 50% of their workforce. They also ceased operations in Nigeria to retain their profit streak.

Sendy relied heavily on external funding and sought to raise \$100 million, but it only succeeded in raising \$26.5 million. Spurred by its unsustainable burn rate and an investor's exit during negotiations for asset sales, the company's valuation dropped from \$80 million to \$60 million in 2022. By 2023, Sendy's CEO announced the company's acquisition. Shortly afterwards, it went into administration [\[12\]](#).

Why did Vibra shut down?

Vibra was a cryptocurrency platform co-founded by Allen Ng and Vincent Li in 2021. The company offered trading, investment, and impact trading services to drive cryptocurrency adoption in Africa. Headquartered in Lagos, Vibra set out on its mission by holding virtual cryptocurrency classes and heavily incentivizing user-related activities, especially through giveaway sessions and raffle draws.

Naturally, this bolstered user activity for some time. However, high customer acquisition costs and market volatility caused financial instability and reduced revenue, leading to the shutdown. Vincent Li officially announced that the company was undergoing a “strategic pivot,” declining probes to comment on why they shut down [\[13\]](#).

Why did Pivo shut down?

Pivo was a Nigerian-based fintech startup co-founded by two women, Ijeoma Akwiku and Nkiru Amadai-Emima. The company offered financial services such as credit loans, digital banking, and insurance to small and medium-scale African businesses. Pivo raised \$2.6 million in seed funding.

Sudden regulatory policies, such as the Central Bank of Nigeria’s redesign of currency notes, tightened cash flow and caused economic turbulence, which Pivo suffered from. To reduce this loss of funds, Pivo strengthened its credit loan requirements, earning it a 98% repayment rate.

Pivo shut down in December 2023 due to a conflict between co-founders. Investors revamped the business guidelines to ensure functionality, but this did not work, and the company eventually closed [\[14\]](#).

Why did Zazuu shut down?

Zazuu was a London-based fintech startup launched by Kay Akinwunmi, Korede Fanilola, Tosin Ekolie, and Tola Alade in 2018. The company offered a cross-border remittance platform that enabled users to compare remittance and exchange rates before making international transfers.

Zazuu’s vision to cater to Africans based in the diaspora was a timely intervention, as the region had the highest remittance rates. However, this vision was halted by a lack of funding and potential partners' hesitation to invest. They also had trouble securing certain operational licenses. Zazuu raised \$2 million as its seed round but shut down in November 2023 after failing to secure its growth funding round [\[15\]](#).

Why did Thepeer shut down?

Thepeer was a fintech startup founded by Kosisochukwu Chike Onoye and Micheal Okoh in 2021. As an API-based payment platform, their services included providing

APIs that businesses could integrate into their websites to facilitate digital transactions [16].

Despite acquiring several licenses required for operation, Thepeer faced compliance issues, which hindered them from providing key services for their users. In 2021, they partnered with Flutterwave to bypass some of these problems. However, slow user adoption led to the decision to shutter operations [17].

Thepeer raised \$2.1 million in seed funding. In April 2024, the co-founders announced they would return the remaining seed funds to their investor, Raba Partnership, and shut down the company.

Why did Gro Intelligence shut down?

Gro Intelligence was an agri-tech startup based in Kenya. Founded by Sara Menker in 2012, the company provided agricultural insights from its database powered by artificial intelligence. In 2021, the company raised \$85 million in series B funding and generated revenue from business transactions with Unilever and other companies. Gro Intelligence was also named one of TIME's most influential companies in 2021 [18].

Gro Intelligence shut down due to its inability to secure funding. Although it secured some financing in March 2024, it still laid off 60% of its staff, including the CEO and COO [19].

Why did Copia shut down?

Copia Global was a Kenyan e-commerce platform founded by Jonathan Lewis and Tracey Turner in 2013. The company leveraged a widely distributed network of local agents offering retail and delivery services. In addition to securing \$123 million in funding, it expanded operations to Uganda and established adequate infrastructure to support its employees and agents.

By 2023, Copia had ceased operations in Uganda and laid off some staff to reduce its unsustainable burn rate. Expanding operations took a heavy toll on the company's finances and stretched its resources thin. Shortly after laying off over a thousand employees, Copia entered administration by May 2024 [20].

Why did RejaReja shut down?

RejaReja was a Kenyan B2B e-commerce platform founded by Mesongo Sibuti and Tesh Mbaabu in 2018. Sheltered under MarketForce, the company provided retailers with goods at wholesale prices from FMGCs within a 24-hour range. They also provided loans for shop owners. Market Force raised \$64.1 million in funding from over thirteen rounds.

RejaReja expanded its operations across five African countries, processing over \$160 million in transaction volume. Although the company constantly made sales, the profit margin was small, and most shopkeepers struggled to repay their loans. This development negatively impacted their cash flow and was a significant player in RejaReja's shutdown. MarketForce shut down RejaReja in April 2024 and announced its pivot to a virtual shopping platform, Chpter [\[21\]](#).

Why did Cova shut down?

Cova was a fintech startup founded by Oluyomi Ojo and Yomi Osamiluyi in 2021 to enable users to aggregate their financial portfolios in one application. The platform provided a unified dashboard showing users' assets, ranging from landed properties to bank and crypto accounts. Users were required to pay a \$10 monthly subscription fee to access Cova's services.

While Cova received \$800,000 in funding from investors led by Olumide Soyombo, the company shut down in January 2024 due to financial instability. Oluyomi Ojo announced this, clarifying that they had some funds left but would not continue operations [\[22\]](#).

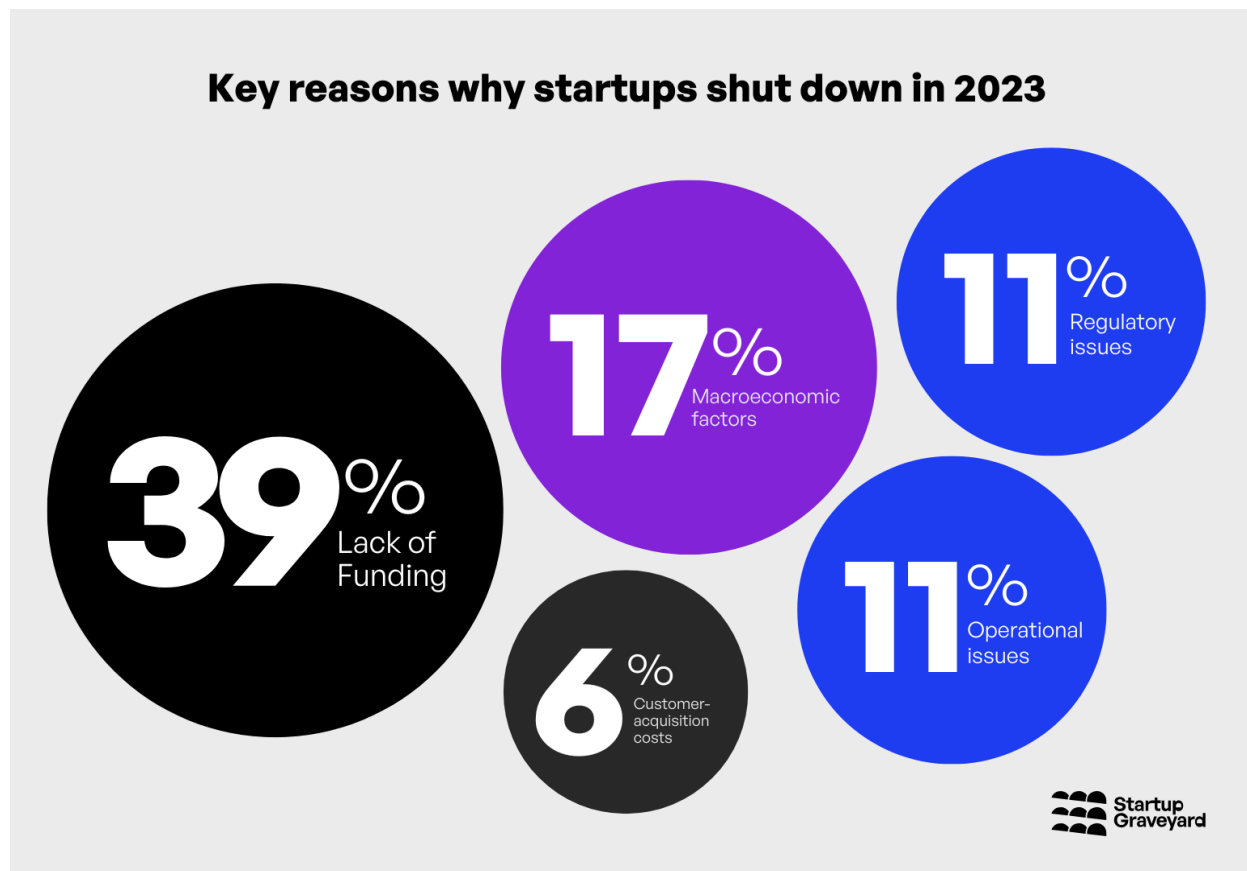
Why did BuyCoins Pro shut down?

BuyCoins Pro is a Nigerian-based startup founded by Timi Ajiboye and Ire Aderinokun in 2017 to offer cryptocurrency-related services. First launched under the name Bitkoin, the company raised \$1.2 million in funding and expanded its services into different segments, all under the mother agency Helicarrier. In 2019, its trading volume was valued at over \$28 million.

BuyCoins Pro experienced a cybersecurity breach, leading to a significant loss of funds. In 2021, the Central Bank of Nigeria ordered all financial institutions to cease

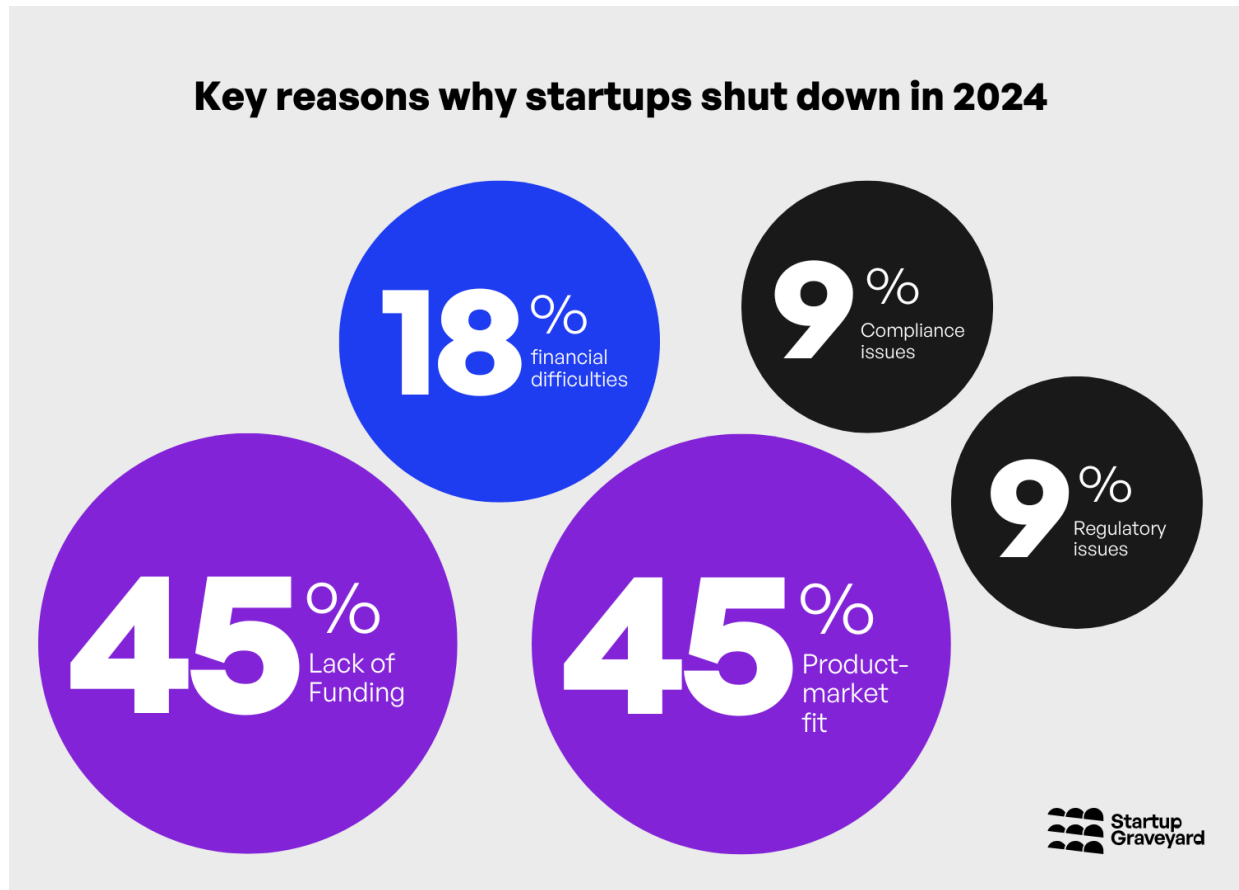
dealings with cryptocurrency exchanges. The company suffered a significant blow and invented an ingenious solution to bypass this problem.

Unofficial sources reported that BuyCoins Pro's services would be discontinued between December 2023 and March 2024. By the first quarter of 2024, Helicarrier officially confirmed that it was ceasing operations under BuyCoins Pro to focus on its core services [23].



Following the detailed case studies reported by Startup Graveyard, African startups shut down primarily due to a lack of funding in 2023. This was corroborated by a general decline in investments that same year [8].

In 2024, lack of funding still remained a major factor; however, a new problem emerged. Some startups expanded beyond their original product offerings to offer novel services, as seen with JumiaFood and BuyCoins Pro. These services were discontinued due to a lack of product-market fit, with the startups announcing a pivot to focus on their core services [23].



Key Factors Contributing to Startups' Failure

Following the case studies of startups that shut down between 2023 and 2024, here are some reasons startups have experienced business setbacks and why some shut down.

Unique Ecosystem Challenges

The startup ecosystem challenges differ across countries due to their disparity in socio-cultural and economic settings.

South Africa

South Africa's start-up ecosystem is ridden with large corporation domination, inequality, and gender disparities, limited access to market opportunities, monopolistic competition, and a lack of financial and social capital. Most of all, the ecosystem is directly impacted by high load-shedding incidences, which results in possible delays in technological development updates and releases [24].

Kenya

Kenya's startup ecosystem is heavily concentrated in urban areas, which reduces fair play. Existing and potential startups also face limited access to funding, inadequate risk capital, a lack of coordination, a weak start-up culture, me-too businesses, an unskilled workforce, a lack of a robust learning and monitoring system, and insufficient policies and guidelines on incubation and commercialization.

Gender disparity is a prominent issue, as men-led startups receive more funding than women-led startups. Men-led startups raise funding through equity, grants, and loans, or an unequal mix of the three, while women-led startups raise funding mostly from grants and loans [25].

Nigeria

Nigeria's startup ecosystem is rife with peculiar reasons for startup failure. They include political instability, lack of access to finance, lack of power supply, and swift and unexpected changes in regulatory policies.

As of 2018, 24% of existing fintech startups cited the unfavourable regulatory environment as a top business challenge. Some startups in the region have changed their business models and developed innovations to suit the current regulatory policies, which has also hindered potential international investment [26].

Notable cases, such as the Central Bank of Nigeria's introduction of the cybersecurity levy and Electronic Money Levy Transfer (EMTL) as government-mandated fees for all electronic transfers, visibly affected fintech startups that gained traction for free mobile money transactions [27] [28].

Mercury's decision to terminate operations in 15 African countries, including Nigeria, is directly related to Nigeria being considered a high-risk country due to coordinated cyber crime and terrorism activity [29].

Financial Challenges

According to Crunchbase, approximately 1,200 startups have achieved unicorn status globally as of 2024. Only nine of these come from Africa. This is mainly due to insufficient capital for sustainable business operations to achieve a billion-dollar valuation. Africa's venture capital (VC) ecosystem is also largely unestablished, with primary concentrations in some countries with high startup activity, such as Nigeria, Kenya, South Africa, and Egypt [29].

African startups receive less funding than their counterparts in developed countries because the VCs here use the same business models as those applied in Silicon Valley. While some criticism can be placed on VCs for not taking the time to understand the African landscape, they also need incentives to invest more. If startups are more likely to shut down than return profit after receiving substantial funding, venture capital will invest less.

Shortage of Human Capital and Required Talent

Brain drain is a common, exacerbating problem experienced by developing countries, constituting a large percentage of Africa. Individuals with specialized skills, training, and work experience leave their home countries in droves to seek greener pastures with better living and work conditions.

There has been an ongoing mismatch between what is taught at the higher learning institutions in these countries and the actual skills needed in industries. This

continued practice has led to a lack of competent workers, competition for available job slots, elevated labour costs, and difficulty in revenue streams for startups [30].

This directly impacts the startup ecosystem, as it presents a limited talent pool and strains its chances of employing skilled professionals who can drive innovation and growth.

A potential shortcut to this problem is hiring staff from other countries with similar workforces, such as India and China. However, this poses several problems, including long-term dependency on external expertise, increased expenses, and staunch growth of home-grown talent [29].

Regulation and Policies

Due to the uncertainty of current regulations, startups often try to maneuver their way out of regulatory mishaps and compliance issues. Building innovative solutions for the market becomes an afterthought, as they find it challenging to scale [29].

Despite the recent wave of bills (startup acts) passed by some African governments favouring startups, entrepreneurship, and small businesses, most have yet to impact the ecosystem. This has slowed startup growth in their respective countries and hindered external investment, as favourable business environments attract substantial funding from diverse sources.

In Africa, the influence of government policies tends to lean more toward the negative than the positive. Nigeria's fintech sector has witnessed an incredible downturn in recent years due to the rise of government policies. Companies have either shut down or have to pay considerable fines in millions of naira [30].

The most recent development in this regard is Opay and Moniepoint's 1 billion naira penalty fee each due to fintech regulation by the Central Bank of Nigeria [31]. Other examples include the cryptocurrency trading ban by the Nigerian government and the high cost of operational licenses for fintech startups.

Investment Risks

Investing in Africa carries more risk than investing in Asia and Latin America [29]. Investors have openly complained about the loss of liquidity after investing, stating that startups need to become profitable in record time or show signs of significant revenue streams to retain investor interest [32].

While the region is plagued by uncertainties that are not the fault of investors, they also significantly widen existing gaps. As stated earlier in this report, the fintech sector is the most established tech sector in the African startup ecosystem, with the highest number of mergers and acquisitions.

Its continued expansion and revenue growth are due to steady investment streams. This has gradually led to preferential investment streams, and other sectors do not get as much funding [33].

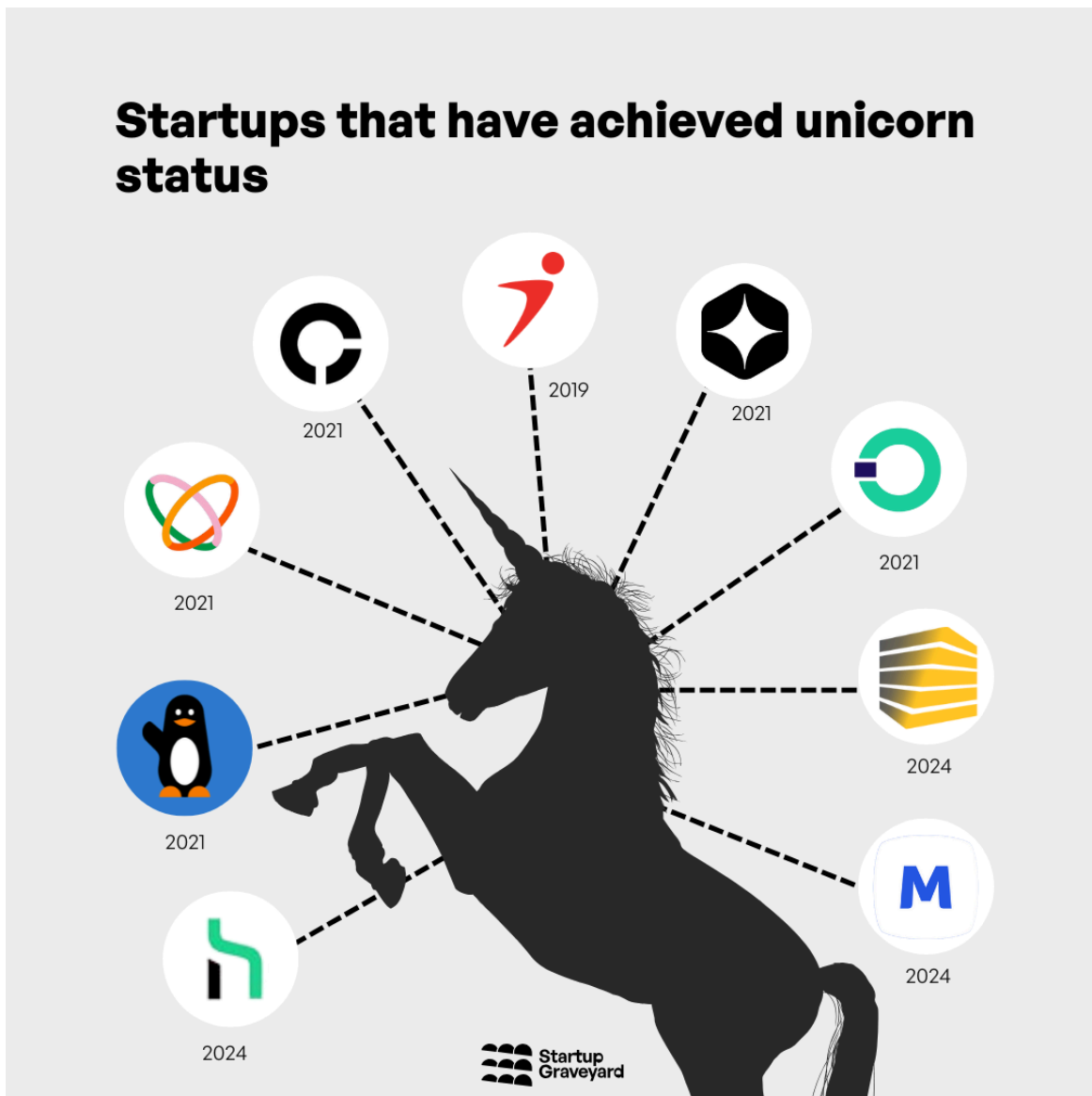
Other reasons startups fail within five years of starting up include a lack of market alignment, poor infrastructure, and poor business management [34].

It is important to note that the reasons why startups fail vary greatly across countries. While similar factors may exist, each country's regulatory policies differ, extending to its currency valuation, economic conditions, receptiveness to small businesses, and level of development.

Success Stories of African Startups

While many African startups have not passed the ideation stage and the first decade of business operations, some have endured despite unfavourable regulatory policies, harsh macroeconomic conditions, and inadequate funding.

Nine startups in the African startup ecosystem have achieved unicorn status as of December 2024. This means they are privately owned companies valued at over \$1 billion. They include Interswitch, Flutterwave, Opay, Wave, Andela, Chipper Cash, MNT-Halan, Moniepoint, and TymeBank [35].



How did they achieve unicorn status?

Interswitch (Nigeria)

In 2002, Mitchell Elegbe founded Interswitch to process efficient digital payments in Nigeria. Between 2003 and 2010, they introduced a national interbank processing system, launched Africa's first chip-based payment method - Verve, and established mobile payments as one of its core services [36].

In 2010, Helios Investment Partners bought two-thirds of the company and provided significant funding. In 2011, InterSwitch acquired 60% of Bankom, a Ugandan business enterprise. During its venture round, InterSwitch raised \$10.5 million. In 2013, it partnered with Discover Financial Services to enhance its payment processing services. In 2014, it became a major shareholder in Paynet Group, an East African payment provider.

In November 2019, Interswitch raised \$200 million in a corporate funding round led by Visa, making it the first fintech unicorn in Africa. Interswitch has invested in five companies, acquired three, and raised \$320.5 million in funding [37].

Flutterwave (Nigeria)

Flutterwave was founded in 2016 by Iyinoluwa Aboyeji, Olugbenga Agboola, and Adeleke Adekoya to provide payment solutions for individuals, small businesses, and large enterprises. In their debut year, they raised \$230,000 in a seed funding round backed by Y-Combinator. In 2017, they received \$50,000 in non-equity assistance from Google's Launchpad Accelerator Program and \$10 million in Series A funding from Green Visor Capital and Greycroft.

Series B funding - \$35 million, came from Greycroft and Headline in 2020. Series C funding amounted to \$170 million, with Avenir and Tiger Global Management leading a dozen other investors. This development made Flutterwave achieve its unicorn status in 2021.

After this, the company raised \$250 million in series D funding in 2022, increasing its valuation to \$3 billion. Since its inception, Flutterwave has acquired and invested in two companies and raised \$474.5 million in funding [38].

Opay (Nigeria)

Opay, also known as Operapay, is a Nigerian-based fintech startup founded by Geir Ivarsoy and Lars Boilesen in 2018. Backed by Opera Limited, a Chinese conglomerate, Opay offers efficient digital payments and related financial services through its mobile application.

Details about Opay's seed funding were not publicly disclosed. The company raised \$50 million in Series A funding in a round led by IDG Capital and Opera Limited in July 2019. In November 2019, they raised \$ 120 million in Series B funding. This was instrumental in its expansion to other African countries outside Nigeria.

In 2021, Opay achieved unicorn status after its Series C round. During this round, Opay raised \$400 million and was evaluated at \$2 billion afterwards. Opay has raised \$570 million in funding. While it has no publicly known investments or acquisitions, the business has expanded to include ORide, a motorbike hailing service, and OFood, a grocery delivery business [39].

Wave (Senegal)

Wave, short for Wave Mobile Money Group, is a Senegalese-based fintech company founded in 2008 by Drew Durbin and Lincoln Quirk. The company aims to reduce transaction fees for mobile money transfers by offering free deposits and withdrawals on its mobile app.

Transaction fees between individuals are capped at 1%. This initiative helped Wave gain massive user traction quickly and made it stand out among its competitors, such as Orange, which felt pressured to replicate some of its tactics [40].

Wave raised \$200 million in Series A funding, led by Founders Fund and Sequoia Heritage. In 2021, it was valued at \$1.7 billion, gaining its unicorn status. To this day, it remains the highest amount an African startup has raised in Series A funding.

In 2022, they raised \$10 million during its Venture Round led by Alameda Research and €90 million in a Debt Financing Round led by the International Financing Corporation (IFC). Wave has raised \$301.7 million in funding over five rounds [41].

Andela (Nigeria)

Andela is a global technology company that matches highly skilled tech and engineering professionals with companies worldwide. It was founded in 2014 by Iyinoluwa Aboyeji, Christina Sass, Jeremy Johnson, Ian Carnevale, Brice Steven Nkengsa, and Nadayar Enegesi [42].

Andela started as a talent scouting and development hub in Lagos, Nigeria, training software engineers to attain global relevance in tech. Following the success of this training model, the company expanded operations to Nairobi, Kenya, in 2015 to tap into the East African tech talent pool. In 2017 and 2018, they moved further into Uganda and Rwanda, respectively. By 2020, Andela switched to a remote model to easily recruit global talent while being headquartered in the United States (U.S.A) [43].

Andela raised \$3.5 million in seed funding during its debut year. In 2015, its Series A funding amounted to \$14 million in a round led by Spark Capital. In 2016, they raised \$26 million in Series B funding. In 2017, they raised \$40 million in a Series C round; in 2019, they raised \$100 million in a Series D investment round led by Generation Investment Management.

In September 2021, Andela raised \$200 million in funding from its Series E round led by SoftBank Vision. This raised the company's valuation to \$1.5 billion, ultimately making it a unicorn.

Andela acquired three companies in 2023 and has raised \$381 million over nine rounds [44].

Chipper Cash

Chipper Cash was co-founded by Ham Serunjogi (Ugandan) and Maijid Moujaled (Ghanaian) in 2018. The company is headquartered in San Francisco, functions under the legal name - Critical Ideas Incorporated, and offers cross-border payments across African countries and from the U.S.A.

Chipper Cash raised \$8.4 million in seed funding in 2019. Its Series A funding summed up to \$13.8 million in June 2020. In November 2020, they raised \$30 million in Series B funding. In May 2021, SVB Capital led a group of investors that raised \$100 million to invest in Chipper Cash's Series C funding.

In November of the same year, another group of investors, led by FTX, extended the Series C funding round with \$150 million. After this round, the company was valued at \$2 billion and earned the unicorn tag.

Chipper Cash acquired Zoona in 2022 and invested in Thepeer. The company has raised \$337.2 million over seven rounds [45].

MNT-Halan (Egypt)

MNT-Halan is an Egyptian fintech company founded by Ahmed Mohsen, Mohammed Aboulnaga, and Mounir Nakhla in 2017. The company provides digital banking services for the predominantly unbanked population in the Middle East and Northern Africa regions. These services include buy-now-pay-later options, digital wallets, and consumer finance.

In 2021, the company raised \$120 million in Series A funding, led by Apis Partners and Development Partners International. In February 2023, it raised \$230 million in Series B funding in a round led by Chimera, raising its valuation to \$1 billion and earning its unicorn status. The Series B extension earned the company \$130 million in the last quarter of 2023 and \$158 million in the first quarter of 2024 [46].

MNT-Halan has acquired four companies, the latest acquisition being Tam Finans in July 2024. The company has raised \$625.7 million in funding [47].

Moniepoint (Nigeria)

Moniepoint, formerly TeamApt, is a financial technology company that provides loan offers, digital banking services, and business management tools for individuals and small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) in Africa.

Founded by Felix Ike and Tosin Eniolorunda in 2015, the company's most popular service is the Moniepoint Point-of-Sale (POS) terminal, which is housed under Moniepoint Microfinance Bank (MFB). In 2022, Moniepoint MFB received its license to operate from the Central Bank of Nigeria.

Moniepoint operates Nigeria's largest financial distribution network and has registered businesses that use its POS machines across every local government. In 2023, MoniePoint announced that it had 10 million active user accounts, processed \$17 billion monthly, and processed \$182 billion in annual transactions [48].

In 2019, Moniepoint received \$2.8 million in seed funding. Between 2019 and 2020, it raised \$15.3 million in Series A funding in a round backed by Quantum Capital Partners. In 2021, its Series B round, backed by Novastar Ventures, raised \$50 million. In 2022, its Series C investment round raised \$50 million at first, with Novastar Ventures and QED Investors leading the round.

The Series C round extended into 2024, where they raised \$110 million in a round led by Development Partners International, earning their unicorn tag [49].

They acquired Kopo Kopo in 2023 and invested in Coro and PayDay the same year. Moniepoint has raised \$233.1 million in funding over eight rounds. The Financial Times ranked it as Africa's fastest-growing fintech in 2023 and 2024 [50].

TymeBank (South Africa)

South Africa's TymeBank is a digital bank founded by Coen Jonker, Rolf Eichweber, and Tjaart van der Waalt in 2012. The company offers financial services such as buy-now-pay-later options (MoreTyme), diverse account options, and debit card services for the lower-income market [51].

In 2021, TymeBank raised \$110 million in Series B funding. In 2023, the Series B round was extended to an additional \$77.8 million, with Blue Earth Capital and

Norrsken22 as lead investors. In December 2024, the company received \$250 million in funding, elevating its valuation to \$1.5 billion and earning the unicorn status. This round was led by Nubank, which invested \$150 million and was backed by other investors, such as M&G Catalyst Fund [52].

TymeBank has raised \$326.5 million over eight rounds of funding [53].

Key Insights on Building Resilient Startups

Understanding the African Startup Ecosystem

The African startup ecosystem has been labelled nascent—a fitting description, as most tech-inclined companies on the continent came into existence just after the dot-com bubble era.

It is a growing sector characterized by economic challenges and unsteady regulatory policies, which differ across countries and regions. Companies that establish and expand here ride this uncertain wave, mapping out potential solutions to problems as they come.

Startups that cater to the African market have some goals in common;

- Attending to uncatered populations, as seen with most fintech startups that aim to “bank the unbanked.”
- Integrating informal & small-medium sized enterprises (SMEs) into the digital economy, as seen with Moniepoint.
- Creating resilient business models that leverage existing economic challenges and deficient infrastructure to address critical needs, as seen with Kenyan-based Twiga Foods.

Existing startups integrate the features listed above into their business models. With the rise of unicorns and fast-growing businesses, the African economic climate is not entirely hostile to businesses. Proper strategies applied according to business requirements can help startups grow past the ideation stage [54].

Are there government policies that support the startup ecosystem?

Since the influx of investments into the African startup scene and the exemplary growth of the beneficiaries, most governments have relaxed policies surrounding establishing new businesses and laws to promote their development.

Tunisia

Tunisia was the first African country to sign a bill into law specially dedicated to the growth and support of startups. This sets a benchmark for how governments can support the inception and development of startups in their respective countries.

The Tunisia Startup Act, or Startup Nation law, was initiated by Yassine Brahim, the Minister for Communications, during Habib Essid's rule in April 2018. The law was intended to boost the Tunisian startup ecosystem by simplifying administrative processes, making it easier for startups to establish themselves, seek funding, and access global markets [55]. By 2022, the Tunisian Ministry of Communications had labeled 773 startups [56].

Senegal

Senegal was the second African country to sign a startup act into law. The Senegalese Startup Act was ratified in 2021 under Macky Sall's administration. The bill governs the development and promotion of startups in the country [57]. Two years later, the Evaluation, Support, and Coordination Commission for Startups (CEAC) was established to promote innovation and conduct startup labelling [58].

Nigeria

Nigeria's former president, Muhammadu Buhari, signed the Nigeria Startup Act (NSA) into law in October 2022 [59]. This initiative was designed to create an enabling environment for startups to thrive and attract investments to the country.

In April 2024, Dr Bosun Tijani, the Minister for Communications, Innovation, and Digital Economy, announced the opening of the Nigeria Startup Portal for labelling. Businesses submit prescribed documents to get their startups officially labelled [60]. As of this announcement, the Startup Portal had over 12,000 registered startups.

The Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC)

DRC's startup act was officially launched at the RDC Startup Act Conference in November 2022. Before this, the bill was signed into law in September and published by the government officially in November. The act was created through a participatory process and involved i4Policy, a Pan-African entity specializing in formulating African startup acts [62].

Other African countries that have established startup acts or are developing similar bills include Kenya, Rwanda, South Africa, Ghana, Ethiopia, Mali, Benin, Togo, and Cote d'Ivoire [63].

How does The African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCTA) impact the startup ecosystem?

The African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCTA) is the African Union's (AU) flagship project created by Agenda 2063. Its objective is to create an integrated market for the free movement of goods and services. Signed by 54 member states in the AU, the AfCTA is currently the largest free trade area in the world based on the number of its signatories. The first trading set took place among eight member states in October 2022 [63].

Combined with the startup acts in individual countries, the AfCTA will allow startups to expand their customer base and attract larger investments. According to the Secretary General of the AfCTA Secretariat, H. E. Wamkele Mene, “the AfCTA sends a strong signal to the international investor community that Africa is open for business, based on a single rule book for trade and investment” [64].

The free trade area allows companies to scale their products beyond their home markets and attract international investment. The fintech sector, in particular, stands to gain more, as digital payment solutions are essential for cross-border e-commerce transactions [64].

Strategies Successful African startups have used to achieve growth

Some African startups have survived unfavourable business conditions and stood out from their competition using these strategies.

Leveraging digital platforms

OmniRetail, a Nigerian B2B e-commerce platform, topped the Financial Times' list of Africa's Fastest-Growing Companies in 2024. The business aims to bridge the gaps in traditional retail distribution networks. OmniRetail's platform connects manufacturers and retailers with distributors of fast-moving consumer goods (FMCGs), which consist mainly of everyday items.

Fragmentation is a significant obstacle to the smooth delivery of FMCGs.

OmniRetail addressed this issue by building apps to digitize all transactions. Mplify digitizes trades between manufacturers and distributors, Omnibiz digitizes trades

between retailers and distributors, and OmniPay is the company's trading payment software.

OmniRetail has expanded its operations to Ghana and the Ivory Coast with plans to expand further. Despite Nigeria's upward inflation trend and harsh macroeconomic conditions, OmniRetail has reduced costs by avoiding infrastructure such as warehouses and storage rooms. Since 2019, OmniRetail has raised \$20 million in debt and equity funding [65].

Diversifying Revenue Streams

Flutterwave initially focused on providing cross-border payment solutions for African countries. To diversify its income streams, it launched other services. Send App by Flutterwave is a low-cost global remittance service, while Flutterwave Store is an e-commerce subsidiary that small business owners can use to set up virtual stores and make global sales [66] [67].

Like Flutterwave, Opay has diversified its revenue sources. Its robust portfolio includes both financial and non-financial services. In addition to its mobile money platform, Opay offers other functional services. ORide, a motorcycle-hailing service, pivoted to OExpress, which offers delivery and logistics services [68]. OFood allows users to order food through its app [69]. OKash is a credit services and lending platform integrated into the Opay app [70].

Diversifying revenue streams reduces the company's reliance on external funding. It also increases the chances of local partnerships, which helps the company better understand its target audience.

Mergers and Acquisitions (M&As)

Mergers and acquisitions are gradually becoming the most common exit for startups [71]. Africa's merger and acquisition landscape has grown significantly over the last ten years. The major sectors that have experienced significant activity in the M&A sector include fintech, IT, telecommunications, energy, and natural resources [72].

The merger of Wasoko and MaxAB is Africa's largest tech merger in 2024. In August 2024, both startups combined Wasoko's retail prowess in East Africa and MaxAB's

business expertise in North Africa to create a vast and efficient B2B e-commerce platform spread across four countries: Kenya, Tanzania, Egypt, and Morocco [73].

In May 2024, Paystack led an investment group to acquire Brass. This was achieved with participation from other fintech startups such as Piggyvest and some angel investors like Olumide Soyombo [74].

In September 2024, Rise announced its official acquisition of Hisa, a Kenyan startup focused on creating educational content and simplified wealth-building solutions. With this development, Rise aims to establish its presence in the East African market [75].

It is important to note that not all M&As signify joint interest in expanding business operations. In most cases, the acquired company loses a significant portion of its autonomy and becomes shadowed by the parent company. It is still considered the best exit strategy for startups and companies.

How can African Startups withstand Economic Downturns?

In 2023, a scholar investigated the factors that support the survival of tech startups during their gestation period in Nigeria. He gathered information by speaking to several founders and conducting a detailed data analysis. He discovered that certain factors are involved, and they constantly interact with each other.

These factors include collaboration, avoiding problematic investors, market acceptance of the product or service, ensuring product/service visibility in the market, continuous founder-customer interaction, adaptation to the environment, and outsmarting your competitors [76].

Collaboration

Three founders acknowledged that collaboration involving several stakeholders helped them achieve their goals for their respective startups. This initiative granted them access to a steady pool of suitable talent for their work teams, scarce resources, and funding—all of which are hard to get as a standalone enterprise. It also helped them make informed decisions about the viability of their products and

the probable success of their business strategies despite inconsistent government regulations [76].

Avoiding Problematic Investors

Most investors enter the Nigerian startup scene with high expectations for the business founders. While the founders need money to fund their business ideas, the investors want to make a profit as quickly as possible. This visibly strains the startup owner and their mode of operation after contracts have been signed.

One of the startup founders described this situation as pivotal: “Some investors usually present conditions that show that they want a major share of your start-up, which demotivates you as a startup founder. The moment you agree, everything changes because over time, you will realize that you are no longer working for yourself but for the investor. You become an employee in the business you founded, and then you become demotivated, eventually leading to business failure.”

Some startup owners shared tips for avoiding this dismal occurrence: bootstrapping techniques, crowdfunding, and internal and external collaboration within the startup ecosystem to secure funding. Those who eventually bargain with investors demand favourable terms and refuse to let them own a high percentage of the company's shareholdings [76].

Market Acceptance of Products or Services

Founders admitted that market research was a vital step in building their startups. They emphasized the need to build and market a product that provides a unique solution and relieves the pain points of the intended target audience.

The steps to ensure market acceptance include conducting an opportunity search, identifying a viable opportunity, creating a unique product that solves a problem, and conducting a survey to view the potential impact of the product on users [76].

Continuous founder-customer interaction

Successful tech startups have attested to conducting market surveys with Minimum Viable Products (MVPs). These surveys gauge customer reviews and feedback on potential products before they are released.

This procedure is cost-effective, and rigorous user testing allows the research and development teams to take notes for product modifications and remodelling. It also requires them to include unique product features so that their final product can withstand market competition [76].

Adaptation to the environment

Due to inconsistent government policies, inflation, and currency depreciation, Nigeria's business sector is uncertain. Startup founders in this region must quickly adapt and remodel their business strategies with new developments to cut losses.

Some startups, especially in the fintech sector, need to be granted government operational licenses to operate. This requires significant capital, exerting pressure on some startups to seek funding at all costs.

Successful tech startups in the region constantly evaluate the business environment, its current challenges, and the best-case scenarios to make a profit in all situations. Most startups evade financial problems by seeking funding from international investors, as in Flutterwave's case [76].

Outsmarting competition

New product offerings that impact users often disrupt market settings and gain traction. Every startup aims to achieve this goal by providing an easy-to-access product that quickly solves customers' needs. The product is made relevant by constantly reviewing market needs and releasing updates and modifications, which are best based on customer feedback and survey reviews [76].

Ensuring product visibility in the market

Product visibility involves making the product recognizable to the target audience in the market. Startup founders have achieved this by advertising on digital platforms and the prominent use of social media for self-promotion.

This process involves several tactics, from creating appropriate media news for different social media channels to using innovative ways to reach a customer base with minimal digital presence [76].

Startup Graveyard's Contribution to Africa's Startup Ecosystem

Globally, the survival rate during early-stage development is only around 10%–20%. This means roughly 80% of digital startups fail during market entry, and Africa is no exception [73]. Some platforms extensively cover startup funding, mergers, and expansion, such as Disrupt Africa's annual reports, which cover individual countries and the continent. However, this does not apply to startup shutdowns.

Startup Graveyard, with the domain name - <https://startupgraveyard.africa>, offers a centralized database for startup shutdowns solely in the African startup ecosystem. There are similar websites, like the Startup Graveyard, with the domain name - <https://startupgraveyard.io/>, which does not cover news about African startups.

The reluctance to discuss startup failures is understandable. It is evident in cases where some founders decline to comment when prompted by journalists to share their stories [77], [78], [79]. However, detailed analyses of what went wrong during business dealings are bound to provide fresh perspectives for startup founders, entrepreneurs, business enthusiasts, investors, venture capitalists, researchers, and everyone interested in Africa's startup and tech ecosystem.

Startup founders know what issues to avoid when embarking on their next business venture. Investors and venture capitalists can use this knowledge to conduct due diligence and determine their risk levels. Extensive documentation of these startup activities provides credible data for researchers.

Startup Graveyard aims to provide valuable insights into the failures of African startups. This annual report presents a significant milestone in the journey towards achieving that goal, serving as a comprehensive source of data concerning startup shutdowns across Africa. Startup Graveyard aims to contribute to Africa's more resilient and innovative startup ecosystem through this initiative.

Conclusion

Africa's startup ecosystem is brimming with potential and, with further expansion and investment, poised to become a stronghold in the global economy. However, the internal problems that plague it will continue to present roadblocks if not properly handled.

The sector needs continuous collaboration between startup founders, the private sector, ministerial agencies, and the governments of their respective countries to provide a favourable business environment—the most essential need of any startup.

If executed properly, this development will have positive ripple effects, prompting the growth and funding of startups, attracting local VCs and international investment, and spurring the training of adequate skilled workers to keep up with workforce demands.

If ignored, the sector will crumble under unfavourable regulatory policies that disrupt business operations and limit access to funding. This will lead to the subsequent shutdown of more startups and diminish African innovation and entrepreneurship.

This report presents case studies of shutdown startups, key factors that led to these developments, and best practices for avoiding them, regardless of country status. These actionable tips will be useful to the builders of today and the founders of the future.

Methodology

Since its inception, Startup Graveyard Africa has documented extensive case studies on startup shutdowns. These studies present the business background, founders, business model, target audience, milestones achieved, and the reason for the shutdown. This trajectory presents the company's overview and actionable insights in a quick read.

Internal Data

We used our case studies and relevant blog articles. We also used percentage figures from the official website - <https://startupgraveyard.africa/>.

Public Data

We used research articles, annual reports, startup database systems, blog posts, articles, and essays. The appendix cites all publicly available data.

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